

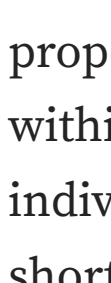
Human Body Proportion

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Udegbe Chiamaka Linda

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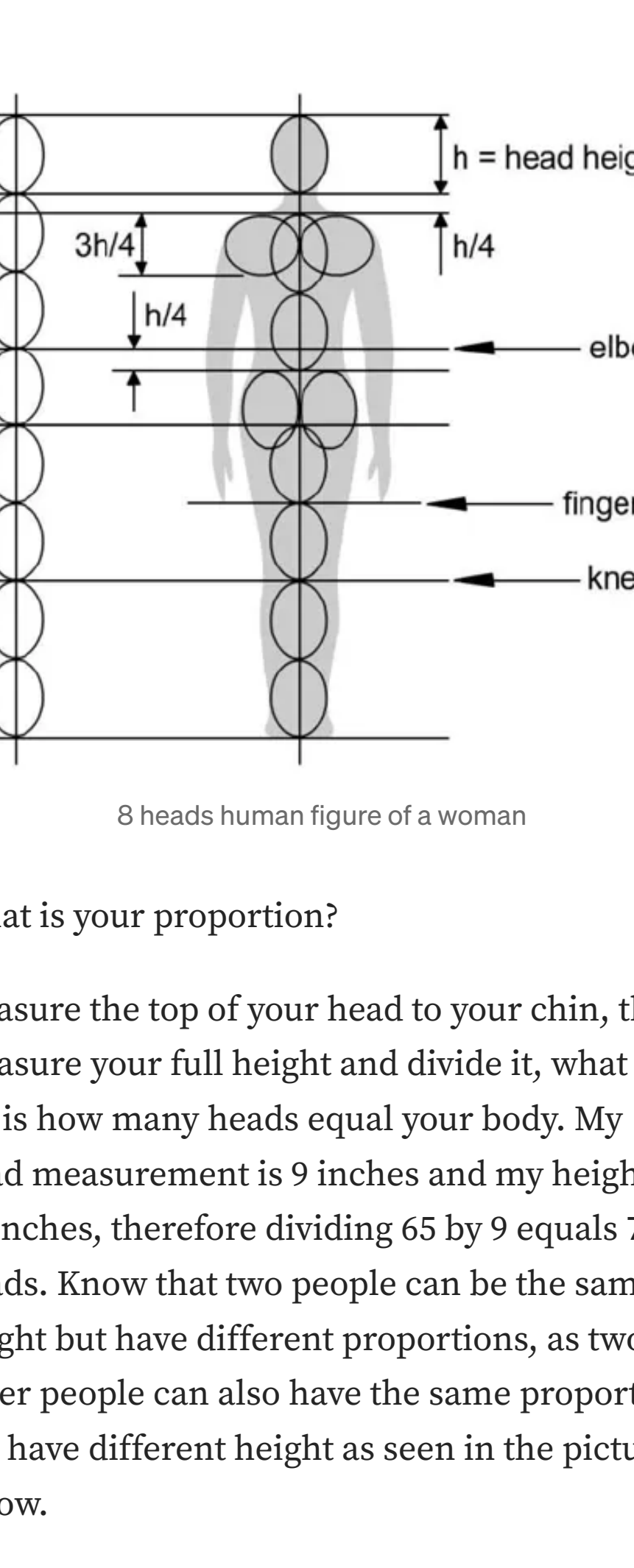
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Ever wondered why the human figure looks so perfectly drawn, unique, or pleasing to the eye and mind? Well, let me explain it to you.

Being an artist, one of the things I had to sit and learn when I decided to start drawing and illustrating professionally, was to start working on knowing my body proportions and face proportions. The human body proportions falls within a very narrow range and varies between individuals, while this may be true, the tall and short people body ratio can be near similar, this is because they equal the same amount of head if divided across individuals. There is no such thing as a perfect body but understanding how proportions work can help you create a near perfect figure and balance to the eyes just like the Fibonacci sequence creates balance to the eyes of the artist and the viewers. Ever seen a baby draw? Can you imagine those crooked drawings and illustration? This drawings are not bad, they just lack proportions and balance to the eyes, they either have short arms or tiny legs, or oversized face and et cetera.

What is Proportion?

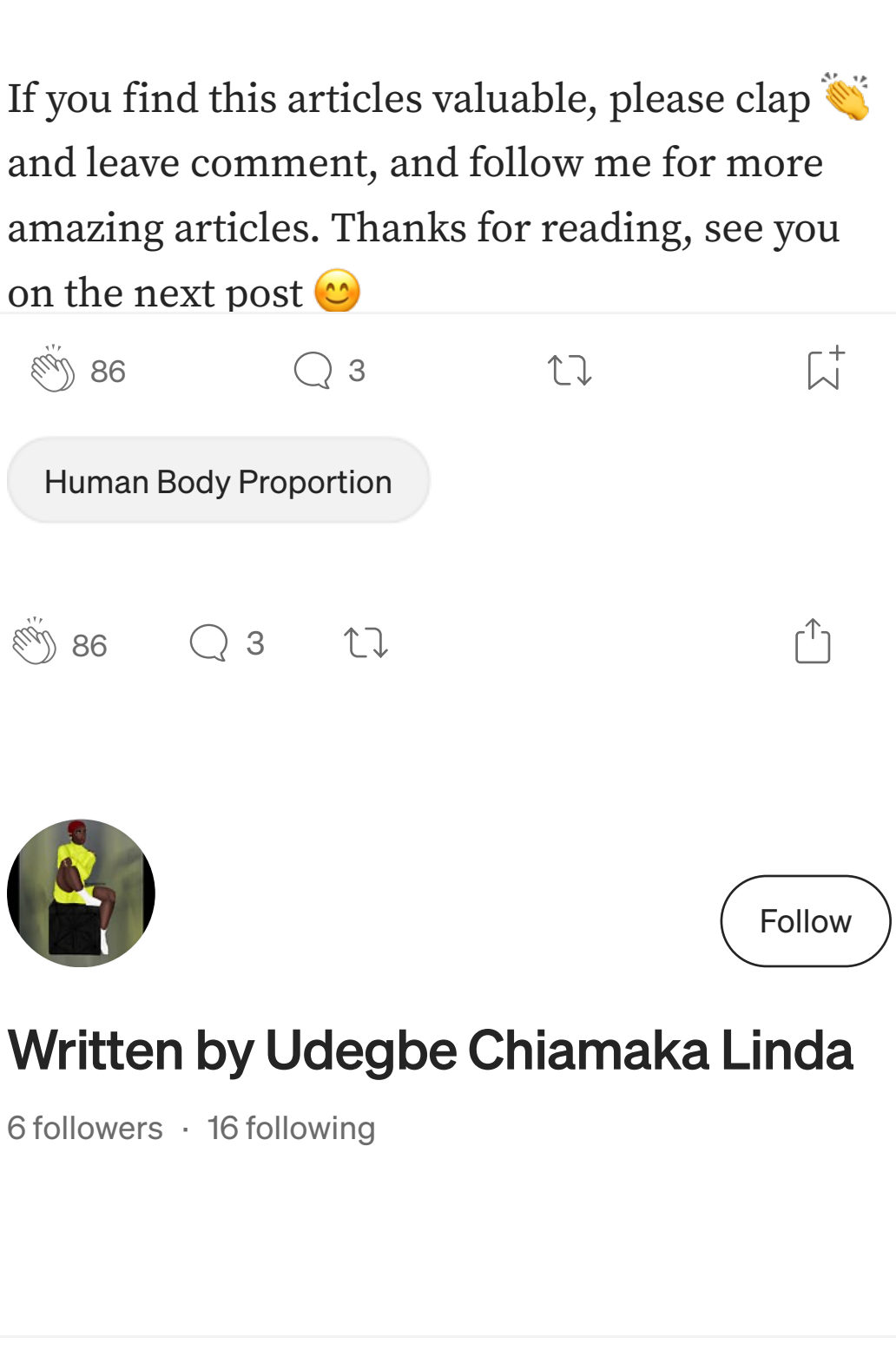
Proportion is the principle of art that refers to relative size. “Proportion refers to the dimensions of a composition and relationships between height, width and depth. How proportion is used will affect how realistic or stylized something seems. Proportion also describes how the sizes of different parts of a piece of art or design relate to each other. The proportions of a composition will affect how pleasing it looks and can be used to draw our attention to particular areas. The use of proportion is essential for creating accurate images. Understanding and using correct proportion in life drawing and portraits allows an artist to create well-balanced, realistic representations of the human form” — (GSCE Arts and Design Revision).



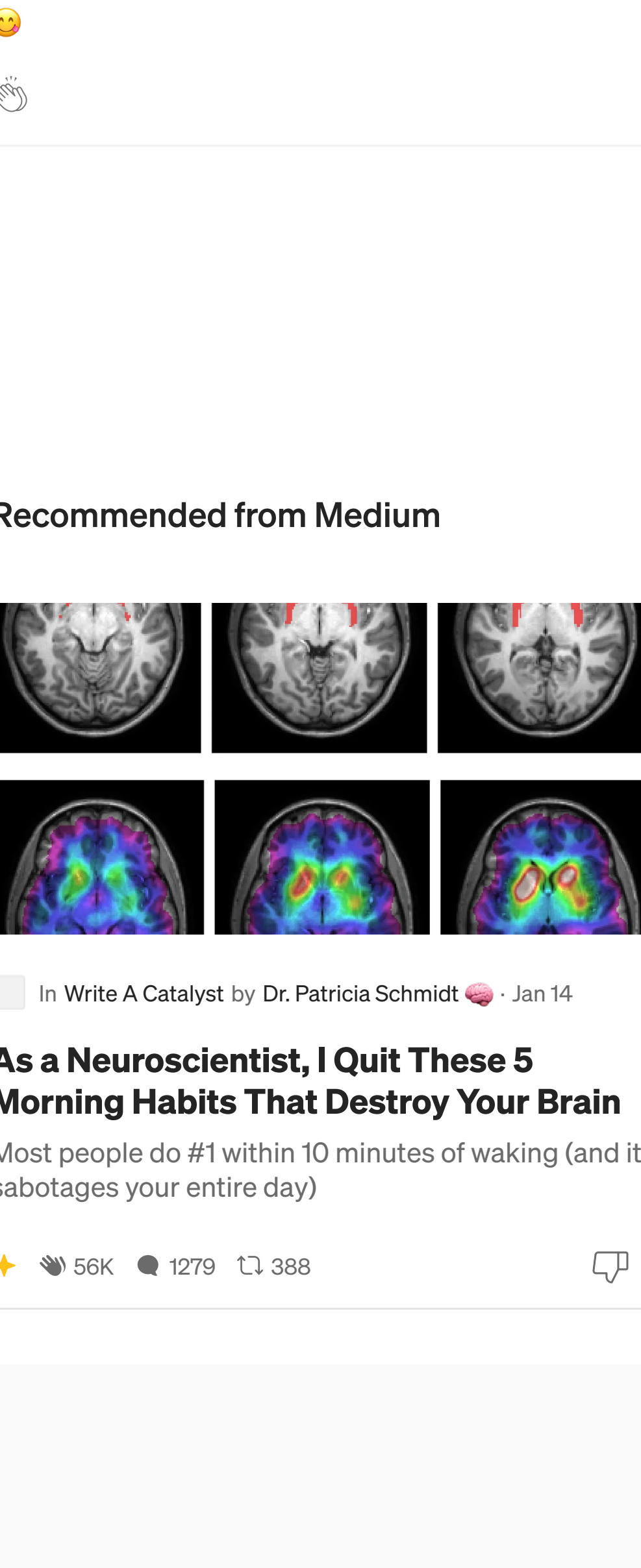
The proportion of human figure by Leonardo Da Vinci themed “Vitruvian Man”

Proportion is also be manipulated in different ways regarding the message an artist is trying to convey, it can be to create a certain feeling about an art Being visually pleasing can seem less important today when visual practitioners engage with a wide range of themes, often requiring distortions and manipulations of reality for the most effective results. El Greco, was one of the art painters that exaggerated most of his human forms. He felt that by “stretching” the human form, he was directing his audience to look upward and to think about God. His figures certainly stretched toward Heaven. Also, by elongating his subjects, El Greco lent them an otherworldly, spiritual sense of being.

Also, Picasso in the early 1920s, made a series of paintings about the relationship between a mother and her child. In this series, figures are thick and heavy looking. Picasso exaggerated the width of the body in comparison to the head, giving his figures a stable, sculptural feeling. This stable feeling communicates a secure, unshakable relationship between a mother and her child — the type of relationship he hoped his children would have with their own mother.



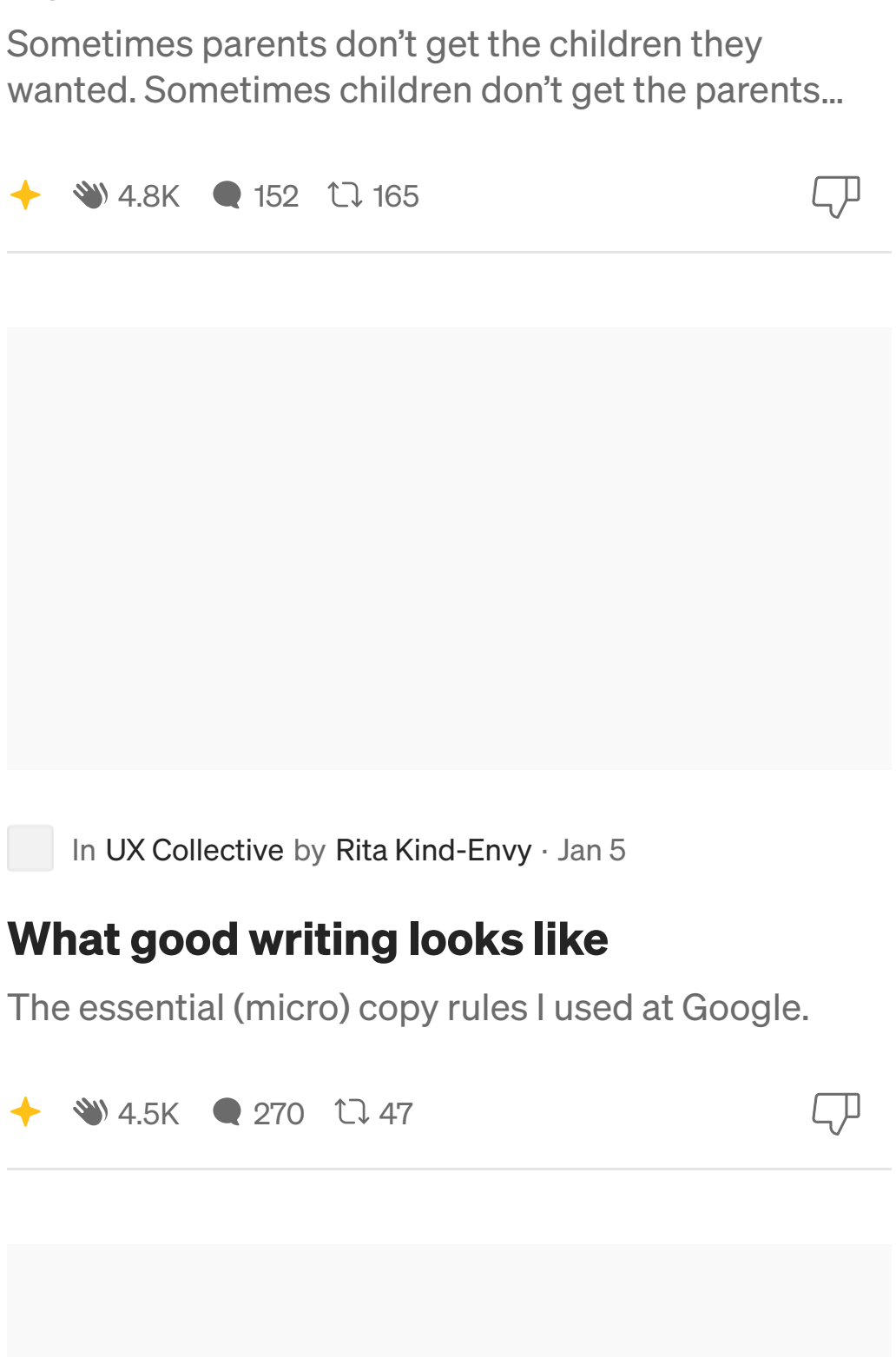
In art, we talk about the human proportion in relation to the head. The average “height to head” ratio of most human is “seven and half heads to one”, but in creation of model figures (croquis) for illustrations especially in women drawing is “nine heads to one” which also is not constant depending on what stature you wish to achieve. This simply means that the head to chin of one individual can be measured a particular amount of times across their body to their feet. It is also important to keep in mind that 99% of the human in this world do not follow this ratio as human differ.



8 heads human figure of a woman

What is your proportion?

Measure the top of your head to your chin, then measure your full height and divide it, what you get is how many heads equal your body. My head measurement is 9 inches and my height is 65 inches, therefore dividing 65 by 9 equals 7.2 heads. Know that two people can be the same height but have different proportions, as two other people can also have the same proportion but have different height as seen in the picture below.



E shock you? E shock me too oo but I soon realized how easy practicing it made my work easier, but like they say, too much of everything is bad, you need to break beyond the basic shapes and steps to be able to draw faster and improve your skill. Here are a few pros and cons about using proportions;

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Pros:

- It serves as a reference guide to understanding different models.
- Memorizing proportions help you draw from imaginations and memory.
- They can look very real and can be used to compare to the proportions of the actual model.
- Memorizing the proportions can help you design figures; meaning you can easily draw a short, tall or a fat person.
- Makes you a professional artist.

Cons:

- Relying heavily on basic proportions can make it difficult for you to understand various individuals, which would limit your drawing process.
- Humans are different, body shapes and sixes differ, therefore no body proportions can not be accepted as a rule.
- Different people with there different understanding of the human body proportions, imposing one system can be a form of knowledge critics.

Conclusion

Let me guess you learnt something new, well I hope you did and if you are a beginner in the art industry, you might want to read deeper into the various ways people use proportions and also about face proportions because it makes up as part of the body.

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